

The Last Week of the Lamb

A Day-by-Day Timeline from the Text

Tracing Every Time Marker in the Gospel Accounts
From the Arrival in Bethany to the Empty Tomb

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All Scripture quotations are from the New American Standard Bible (NASB).

Introduction: What the Text Gives Us

The events of Jesus' final week are recorded in all four Gospels. Each account provides different details, different emphases, and different time markers. When these accounts are laid side by side and examined carefully, they provide enough information to reconstruct a day-by-day timeline from Jesus' arrival in Bethany through the discovery of the empty tomb.

This study does not begin with tradition and work backward. It does not assume "Palm Sunday" or "Good Friday" or "Easter" and then fit the text into those inherited frameworks. None of those terms appear in Scripture. They are the products of church tradition, not the text itself.

Instead, this study begins with the textual evidence — the specific time markers, relative day references, and named events in the Gospel accounts — and follows them to wherever they lead. The method is simple: let the text speak. Where the text is explicit, we follow it. Where it is silent, we say so. Where a conclusion requires inference, we identify it as such and show our reasoning.

Two foundational studies inform this timeline and are referenced throughout:

Three Days and Three Nights — the full textual argument for three literal days and three nights between the crucifixion and the resurrection, including every prediction Jesus made, the Jonah pattern, the two-Sabbath evidence from Luke 23:56 and Mark 16:1, and the counting table.

Understanding the Hebrew Calendar — a reader-friendly explainer covering days beginning at sundown (Genesis 1:5), Hebrew months, Nisan dates, and the two kinds of Sabbath (weekly and feast-day "high days").

If you have not read those two studies, they will provide essential context for what follows. The present study builds on both of them.

Part One: The Fixed Anchor

Every timeline needs an anchor — a fixed point from which everything else can be measured. In this study, the fixed anchor is the day of the crucifixion.

As demonstrated in the companion study, Three Days and Three Nights, the text requires a Wednesday crucifixion. The evidence is summarized briefly here.

What Jesus Said

Matthew 12:40 — *“For just as Jonah was three days and three nights in the belly of the sea monster, so will the Son of Man be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth.”*

Jesus specified both days and nights, gave a count of three for each, and anchored the prediction to Jonah 1:17 as a direct, measurable parallel. He also said “on the third day” (Matthew 16:21; 17:23; 20:19; Luke 9:22; 18:33; 24:7; 24:46), “after three days” (Mark 8:31; 9:31; 10:34), and “in three days” (John 2:19). Even His enemies took it literally (Matthew 27:63–64).

What John Told Us

John 19:31 — *“Then the Jews, because it was the day of preparation, so that the bodies would not remain on the cross on the Sabbath (for that Sabbath was a high day), asked Pilate that their legs might be broken, and that they might be taken away.”*

John goes out of his way to flag that the Sabbath following the crucifixion was not the regular weekly Sabbath — it was a “high day.” Leviticus 23:5–7 identifies this: the first day of the Feast of Unleavened Bread (Nisan 15) was a commanded Sabbath rest regardless of what day of the week it fell on.

What the Spice Sequence Demands

Luke 23:55–56 — *“Now the women who had come with Him out of Galilee followed, and saw the tomb and how His body was laid. Then they returned and prepared spices and perfumes. And on the Sabbath they rested according to the commandment.”*

Mark 16:1 — *“When the Sabbath was over, Mary Magdalene, and Mary the mother of James, and Salome, bought spices, so that they might come and anoint Him.”*

Luke says the women prepared spices before resting on the Sabbath. Mark says they bought the spices after the Sabbath was over. You cannot prepare what you have not yet purchased. The only resolution is two different Sabbaths with a working day between

them: the high-day Sabbath (Nisan 15, Thursday), then an ordinary day for buying and preparing spices (Friday), then the weekly Sabbath (Saturday).

The Count

If the crucifixion occurred on Wednesday (Nisan 14), with burial completed before sundown:

Period	Night	Day	Event
Wed sundown – Thu sundown	Night 1	Day 1	High-day Sabbath (Feast of Unleavened Bread)
Thu sundown – Fri sundown	Night 2	Day 2	Ordinary day — spices bought and prepared
Fri sundown – Sat sundown	Night 3	Day 3	Weekly Sabbath (Saturday)
After Sat sundown			RISEN — Tomb found empty Sunday dawn

Three days. Three nights. Just as Jonah was in the belly of the fish. “On the third day” — risen. “After three days” — risen. No partial-day arguments required.

The Discovery, Not the Moment

One clarification is important. All four Gospel accounts agree that the women came to the tomb early on the first day of the week (Sunday) and found it already empty. Not one of them describes the moment of resurrection.

John 20:1 — *“Now on the first day of the week Mary Magdalene came early to the tomb, while it was still dark, and saw the stone already taken away from the tomb.”*

He was already risen when they arrived. The tomb was already empty. What the text gives us is a latest possible time — before Sunday dawn — but not the exact moment. In the Wednesday timeline, three full nights and three full days from burial before sundown Wednesday would complete at sundown Saturday. In Hebrew reckoning, sundown Saturday is already the beginning of the first day of the week. The resurrection could have occurred right at that boundary — fitting both “on the third day” and the first day of the week simultaneously.

Mark 16:9 is sometimes cited as saying He rose on Sunday morning. But the Greek allows “early on the first day of the week” to modify “appeared,” not “risen” — it is a punctuation question, not a word question. And Mark 16:9–20 has the well-known textual variant issue; many early manuscripts do not include these verses, and the NASB flags them accordingly.

The text says the tomb was found empty Sunday morning. It does not say He rose Sunday morning. That is a meaningful distinction.

The fixed anchor: Nisan 14 — Wednesday — is the day of the crucifixion.

Part Two: Tracing Backward from the Anchor

With Wednesday (Nisan 14) established as the crucifixion day, we can now work backward through the Gospel accounts to determine where each event in the final week falls. Two Gospel writers provide specific time markers that make this possible: Mark, who uses a sequence of “next day” references, and John, who provides a numerical count from the Passover.

Mark’s “Next Day” Sequence

Mark’s passion week narrative provides the clearest sequence of relative time markers in any of the Gospels. Working backward from the known anchor:

Mark 14:1 — “Two Days Before”

Mark 14:1 — *“Now the Passover and Unleavened Bread were two days away; and the chief priests and the scribes were seeking how to seize Him by stealth and kill Him.”*

If the Passover (Nisan 14) is Wednesday, “two days away” places this statement on Monday (Nisan 12). This falls at the end of a block of teaching and confrontation that includes the examination by the chief priests, Pharisees, Sadducees, and scribes, and the Olivet Discourse.

Mark 11:20 — “In the Morning”

Mark 11:20 — *“As they were passing by in the morning, they saw the fig tree withered from the roots up.”*

This is the morning after Jesus cursed the fig tree. The disciples see it withered, and the day continues with teaching. If this is Monday morning (Nisan 12), then the fig tree was cursed the previous day — Sunday (Nisan 11).

Mark 11:12–15 — “On the Next Day”

Mark 11:12 — *“On the next day, when they had left Bethany, He was hungry.”*

This is the day Jesus cursed the fig tree and then entered the temple and drove out the merchants (Mark 11:15–17). “The next day” after what? After the entry into Jerusalem described in Mark 11:1–11.

If this day — the fig tree and temple cleansing — is Sunday (Nisan 11), then the entry into Jerusalem was the day before: Saturday (Nisan 10).

Mark 11:1–11 — The Entry

Mark describes Jesus’ entry into Jerusalem. The crowds respond. He enters the temple. And then Mark adds a detail that is easy to overlook:

Mark 11:11 — *“Jesus entered Jerusalem and came into the temple; and after looking around at everything, He left for Bethany with the twelve, since it was already late.”*

He entered. He looked around. He left. He did not teach. He did not cleanse the temple. He did not confront anyone. He came, observed, and withdrew to Bethany because it was late.

This remarkably restrained entry makes complete sense if it was the Sabbath. He enters, He is received, the crowd does what the crowd does, and He returns to Bethany. No commerce, no confrontation, no labor. The action begins “the next day” — when it is no longer the Sabbath.

Mark’s Sequence Summary

Nisan	Day	Weekday	Event (from Mark)
Nisan 10	Day 1	Saturday	Entry into Jerusalem. Enters temple, looks around, leaves for Bethany (11:1–11).
Nisan 11	Day 2	Sunday	Fig tree cursed. Temple cleansed (11:12–19).
Nisan 12	Day 3	Monday	Withered fig tree seen. Teaching, confrontations, Olivet Discourse. “Two days before the Passover” (11:20–13:37; 14:1).
Nisan 13	Day 4	Tuesday	Judas goes to the chief priests (14:10–11). Evening (beginning Nisan 14): Last Supper, Gethsemane, arrest.
Nisan 14	Day 5	Wednesday	Trials. Crucifixion ~3 PM. Burial before sundown.

Part Three: John's Independent Confirmation

John's Gospel provides a completely independent set of time markers that can be tested against Mark's sequence. John does not use "the next day" chains from the entry. Instead, he gives a specific numerical count from a different starting point.

John 12:1 — "Six Days Before the Passover"

John 12:1 — *"Jesus, therefore, six days before the Passover, came to Bethany where Lazarus was, whom Jesus had raised from the dead."*

John 12:2 — *"So they made Him a supper there, and Martha was serving; but Lazarus was one of those reclining at the table with Him."*

Jesus arrives in Bethany, and a supper is held at the home of Lazarus. This is the dinner where Mary anoints Jesus' feet with costly perfume (John 12:3). The supper happens the same day He arrives — or at least John presents them together as one event.

To determine what day this is, we need to resolve two questions: what does "the Passover" mean in this context, and how do we count "six days before"?

The Counting Question

Jewish reckoning typically used inclusive counting. When the text says "on the third day," it counts the starting day as day one. This pattern is seen throughout the Old Testament — for example, "after three days" and "on the third day" are used interchangeably (compare 2 Chronicles 10:5 and 10:12).

Taking "the Passover" as Nisan 14 (the day the lamb is killed, consistent with how John uses the term throughout his passion narrative), and counting inclusively:

Count	Nisan Date	Weekday	Event
Day 1	Nisan 14	Wednesday	Passover (the reference point)
Day 2	Nisan 13	Tuesday	
Day 3	Nisan 12	Monday	
Day 4	Nisan 11	Sunday	
Day 5	Nisan 10	Saturday	
Day 6	Nisan 9	Friday	Jesus arrives in Bethany. Supper at Lazarus's house.

The inclusive count places Jesus' arrival in Bethany on Friday (Nisan 9). The supper takes place that evening — which, in Hebrew reckoning, is the beginning of Nisan 10

(Saturday). Sharing a Sabbath meal was not only permitted, it was customary in Jewish life. Martha serving at a Sabbath meal raises no issues at all.

John 12:12 — “On the Next Day”

John 12:12 — *“On the next day the large crowd who had come to the feast, when they heard that Jesus was coming to Jerusalem...”*

The “next day” after the Friday arrival and evening supper is Saturday — and this is the day the crowd goes out to meet Jesus as He enters Jerusalem.

Result: John’s “six days before the Passover” counted inclusively places the entry into Jerusalem on Saturday, Nisan 10 — exactly where Mark’s “next day” sequence independently places it.

Testing the Alternative: Exclusive Counting

For thoroughness, we should also test the exclusive count — where the Passover itself is not counted as day one, but as day zero.

Under the exclusive count, six days before Nisan 14 would be Nisan 8 (Thursday). Jesus arrives in Bethany on Thursday. “On the next day” (John 12:12) would be Friday. The entry into Jerusalem would be on Friday.

This creates a significant practical problem. In Mark’s sequence, “the next day” after the entry is when Jesus cursed the fig tree and cleansed the temple (Mark 11:12–17). If the entry is Friday, then the temple cleansing falls on Saturday — the weekly Sabbath.

The temple cleansing involved overturning tables, driving out merchants, and stopping people from carrying goods through the temple courts (Mark 11:15–16). On the weekly Sabbath, the commercial activity that Jesus confronted would not have been operating. The money changers and dove sellers operated on working days, especially in the days leading up to the feast when demand was highest. A Sabbath temple cleansing does not work practically — there would have been no merchants to drive out.

The inclusive count avoids this problem entirely. If the entry is Saturday and “the next day” is Sunday, the temple cleansing falls on an ordinary working day when commercial activity would be in full operation.

This practical test strongly favors the inclusive count. And the inclusive count is consistent with standard Jewish reckoning as seen elsewhere in Scripture.

Part Four: The Entry on the Sabbath

Both Mark's sequence and John's count place the entry into Jerusalem on Saturday — the weekly Sabbath. Does this create a problem?

Consider what the text says Jesus actually did that day. Mark 11:11 says He entered Jerusalem, came into the temple, looked around at everything, and left for Bethany because it was already late. That is the full extent of His activity. No teaching. No confrontation. No cleansing. Just arrival, observation, and departure.

This restraint actually makes more sense on the Sabbath than on any other day. If it were an ordinary working day and the money changers were set up right in front of Him, why would He simply look around and leave? The most natural explanation for His restraint is that it was the Sabbath — the commercial activity was not happening, and He was not going to initiate a confrontation on the rest day. He comes back the next day, Sunday, when the merchants are set up and operating, and then He acts.

The Crowd's Actions

The crowd laid garments on the road and took branches. John 12:13 says they “took the branches of the palm trees.” The Greek word (*elabon*) means “took” — it does not necessarily mean “cut.” They may have taken branches that were already available, already cut, or fallen. Mark 11:8 does use language suggesting some cut leafy branches from the fields, but these are the crowd's actions, not His.

Laying a cloak on the road is no more labor than removing it from your back. And the distance from Bethany to Jerusalem was within a Sabbath day's journey (compare Acts 1:12 — less than two miles). Riding a donkey was not considered labor.

The Pharisees' Silence

The Pharisees were watching Jesus constantly for any Sabbath violation. They had previously challenged Him for healing on the Sabbath (Mark 3:1–6; Luke 13:10–17; 14:1–6; John 5:1–18; 9:1–16). If the entry had constituted a Sabbath violation, they would have seized on it.

The text records no such objection. What they did say was “Teacher, rebuke Your disciples” (Luke 19:39). They objected to the messianic claims — not to any Sabbath-breaking activity. This silence from the very people who scrutinized His every move on the Sabbath is a strong indicator that no violation occurred.

Nisan 10 and the Passover Lamb

Exodus 12:3 — *“Speak to all the congregation of Israel, saying, ‘On the tenth of this month they are each one to take a lamb for themselves, according to their fathers’ households, a lamb for each household.’”*

Nisan 10 was the day the Passover lamb was selected — brought into the household and set apart for inspection until Nisan 14, when it would be killed. In the Wednesday crucifixion timeline, Nisan 10 falls on Saturday. Jesus entering Jerusalem on Nisan 10 corresponds precisely to the Passover lamb being selected on the day God appointed for that purpose.

It is important to note honestly that this connection is a typological inference, not an explicit Gospel statement. No Gospel writer says “Jesus entered Jerusalem on Nisan 10.” We arrive at that date by counting backward through the time markers. But when two independent counts (Mark’s and John’s) both land on the same day, and that day happens to be the day Exodus 12 commands the lamb to be selected, the convergence is worth noting.

The typological inference and the textual evidence arrive at the same place independently.

Part Five: Verification from Matthew and Luke

The timeline so far has been built primarily from Mark's "next day" sequence and John's "six days before the Passover" count. Before committing to this timeline, we should examine Matthew and Luke for any time markers that might confirm, add detail, or contradict what Mark and John have given us.

Matthew's Account

The Entry (Matthew 21:1–11)

Matthew provides no day of the week, no Nisan date, and no relative time marker such as "the next day." He simply begins the narrative. No contradiction, no additional anchor.

The Temple Cleansing (Matthew 21:12–13)

Matthew places the temple cleansing immediately after the entry with no time break. But Matthew is known for topical rather than strictly chronological arrangement. Mark, who is generally regarded as the most chronologically sequential of the Synoptics, places the cleansing on "the next day" after the entry (Mark 11:12–15). Matthew appears to compress two days into one narrative unit. This is a difference in literary arrangement, not a chronological conflict. Importantly, Matthew does not say "on the same day." He simply moves from one event to the next without a time marker.

The Fig Tree (Matthew 21:18–22)

Matthew says "in the morning, when He was returning to the city, He became hungry." He sees the fig tree and curses it. In Mark's sequence, the cursing happens before the temple cleansing (Mark 11:12–14), and the disciples notice it withered the next morning (Mark 11:20). Matthew compresses the cursing and the withering into one scene. Again — different arrangement, not a different timeline. And "in the morning" is consistent with a new day, matching Mark's "on the next day."

The Confrontations (Matthew 21:23–23:39)

The extended examination of Jesus by the chief priests, elders, Pharisees, Sadducees, and scribes. No time markers are given. These fit naturally within the teaching days (Nisan 11–12 in the timeline).

The Olivet Discourse (Matthew 24–25)

No new time marker. Flows directly from the temple confrontations.

Matthew 26:1–2 — "After Two Days"

Matthew 26:1–2 — *"When Jesus had finished all these words, He said to His disciples, 'You know that after two days the Passover is coming, and the Son of Man is to be handed over for crucifixion.'"*

This is a time anchor. “After two days” means the Passover is two days away. If the Passover (Nisan 14) is Wednesday, this statement was made on Monday (Nisan 12). This confirms exactly where the timeline places the end of the teaching block — Monday. Matthew and Mark agree: Monday is “two days before” the Passover.

The Anointing at Bethany (Matthew 26:6–13)

Matthew places an anointing at the house of Simon the leper after the “two days before Passover” statement. John places an anointing at Lazarus’s house before the entry (John 12:1–8). The details differ: John says Mary anointed His feet; Matthew says the woman poured it on His head. John’s setting is Lazarus’s house; Matthew’s is Simon the leper’s house. These may be two separate anointings at different points in the week. But even if they are the same event arranged differently by each author, neither provides a time marker that conflicts with the timeline. Matthew does not say “on that same day” — he places it in the narrative without specifying the exact chronological relationship.

The Passover Preparation (Matthew 26:17)

Matthew 26:17 — *“Now on the first day of Unleavened Bread the disciples came to Jesus and asked, ‘Where do You want us to prepare for You to eat the Passover?’”*

The phrase “first day of Unleavened Bread” is used loosely here. Technically, the Feast of Unleavened Bread begins Nisan 15. But the term was used colloquially to include Nisan 14, the day the leaven was removed from the house and the lamb was prepared. This fits within the Tuesday daytime leading into Tuesday evening — the beginning of Nisan 14 in Hebrew reckoning. Consistent with the timeline.

Matthew’s Verdict

Nothing contradicts. The “after two days” marker confirms Monday for the teaching block. The compression of the temple cleansing and fig tree events is a literary arrangement difference, not a chronological conflict. No new time anchors challenge the timeline.

Luke's Account

The Entry (Luke 19:28–44)

No day given. No date. No relative time marker. Luke simply says “He was approaching” and narrates the entry. No conflict.

The Temple Cleansing (Luke 19:45–46)

Like Matthew, Luke places it immediately after the entry without a time break. Same situation as Matthew — narrative compression, not a chronological claim. No conflict with Mark's “next day” placement.

“Teaching Daily” (Luke 19:47–48)

Luke 19:47 — *“And He was teaching daily in the temple; but the chief priests and the scribes and the leading men among the people were trying to destroy Him.”*

This is significant. The word “daily” (Greek: kath' hēmeran) indicates that Jesus taught in the temple over multiple days, not just one. This is consistent with the timeline's placement of teaching and examination across Nisan 11 and 12. Luke confirms it was not a one-day event.

The Confrontations and Olivet Discourse (Luke 20–21)

No specific day markers. These fit within the “teaching daily” framework without any chronological tension.

The Passover Approaching (Luke 22:1)

Luke 22:1 — *“Now the Feast of Unleavened Bread, which is called the Passover, was approaching.”*

No specific day count like Matthew's “after two days.” Just “approaching.” No conflict.

The Passover Preparation (Luke 22:7)

Luke 22:7 — *“Then came the first day of Unleavened Bread on which the Passover lamb had to be sacrificed.”*

Same colloquial usage as Matthew 26:17 — referring to Nisan 14, the preparation and slaughter day. The disciples are sent to prepare the room. Consistent.

Luke 22:15 — “Before I Suffer”

Luke 22:15 — *“I have earnestly desired to eat this Passover with you before I suffer.”*

This word “before” carries particular weight in the context of this study. As addressed in the companion study on the John timing discrepancy, Jesus ate the Passover with His

disciples ahead of the official national observance because He knew He would be dead by then. He could not simultaneously eat the Passover and be the Passover sacrifice. Luke 22:15 reflects that urgency and awareness.

The Preparation Day and the Sabbath (Luke 23:54–56)

Luke 23:54 — *“It was the preparation day, and the Sabbath was about to begin.”*

This confirms the crucifixion day was a preparation day before a Sabbath. The spice passage that follows (Luke 23:55–56) is the critical counterpart to Mark 16:1 in the two-Sabbath argument, as detailed in Part One.

The Emmaus Road — “The Third Day” (Luke 24:21)

Luke 24:21 — *“But we were hoping that it was He who was going to redeem Israel. Indeed, besides all this, it is the third day since these things happened.”*

This passage is sometimes raised as a challenge to the Wednesday crucifixion. If this conversation happens Sunday afternoon, and it is “the third day since these things happened,” counting backward would seem to point to Friday: day three = Sunday, day two = Saturday, day one = Friday.

But the phrase requires careful attention. “Since these things happened” — what things? The disciples on the road have just described not only the crucifixion but also the chief priests handing Him over, the condemnation, and the events surrounding His death and burial. In Matthew 27:62–66, the guard was posted on “the next day, the one after the preparation” — that is Thursday in the timeline (Nisan 15, the high-day Sabbath).

If “these things” includes the securing of the tomb on Thursday, then counting from Thursday: day one = Friday, day two = Saturday, day three = Sunday. That fits the Wednesday timeline precisely.

The disciples are not doing precise calendar math. They are saying “it’s been about three days since this whole sequence of events took place.” The last official action taken against Jesus — the posting of the guard — was Thursday. Sunday is the third day from that.

Luke’s Verdict

Nothing contradicts. “Teaching daily” confirms multiple days of examination. The spice preparation in 23:56 is the essential half of the two-Sabbath evidence. And the Emmaus road “third day” statement aligns with the Wednesday timeline when “these things” is understood to include the full sequence of events, not just the crucifixion alone.

Part Six: The Complete Timeline

Having traced every time marker in all four Gospel accounts, the following timeline emerges. Every entry is anchored to at least one explicit textual reference. Where typological parallels from Exodus 12 align, they are noted — but the timeline itself stands on the Gospel text alone.

Nisan	Weekday	Exodus 12	Event
9	Friday	—	Jesus arrives in Bethany. Supper at Lazarus's house. Mary anoints His feet (John 12:1–8). “Six days before the Passover.”
10	Saturday	<i>Lamb selected</i>	Entry into Jerusalem. Crowd responds. Enters temple, looks around, returns to Bethany (Mark 11:1–11; John 12:12–19). “On the next day” after the Bethany supper.
11	Sunday	<i>Inspection 1</i>	Fig tree cursed. Temple cleansed (Mark 11:12–19). “The next day” after the entry.
12	Monday	<i>Inspection 2</i>	Fig tree withered. Teaching, confrontations, Olivet Discourse. “After two days is the Passover” (Mark 14:1; Matt 26:2). “Teaching daily” (Luke 19:47).
13	Tuesday	<i>Inspection 3</i>	Judas arranges betrayal (Mark 14:10–11). Evening (beginning Nisan 14): Last Supper, Gethsemane, arrest.
14	Wednesday	Lamb killed	Trials. Crucifixion ~3 PM (the ninth hour). Burial before sundown. “ <i>The day of preparation before a Sabbath that was “a high day” (John 19:31).</i> ”
15	Thursday	—	High-day Sabbath — Feast of Unleavened Bread (Lev 23:6–7). Women rest. Guard posted (Matt 27:62–66). Night 1, Day 1 in the tomb.
16	Friday	—	Ordinary working day. Spices bought (Mark 16:1) and prepared (Luke 23:56). Night 2, Day 2 in the tomb.
17	Saturday	—	Weekly Sabbath. Women rest “according to the commandment” (Luke 23:56). Night 3, Day 3 in the tomb.
—	Sunday	—	Tomb found empty at dawn. He is risen. (Matt 28:1; Mark 16:2; Luke 24:1; John 20:1)

Part Seven: What the Text Says and What It Does Not

This study has followed the time markers that the Gospel writers provided and traced them to their conclusions. Before closing, it is important to distinguish between what the text explicitly states and what we have inferred.

What the Text Explicitly States

Jesus predicted He would be three days and three nights in the heart of the earth, tied directly to Jonah's three days and three nights (Matthew 12:40). The Sabbath after the crucifixion was a "high day," not the regular weekly Sabbath (John 19:31). The first day of Unleavened Bread (Nisan 15) was a commanded Sabbath rest regardless of the day of the week (Leviticus 23:6–7). The women bought spices after the Sabbath (Mark 16:1) and prepared them before resting on the Sabbath (Luke 23:56). The Passover was "two days away" during the teaching block (Mark 14:1; Matthew 26:2). Jesus came to Bethany "six days before the Passover" (John 12:1). The entry into Jerusalem was "on the next day" after the Bethany supper (John 12:12). The fig tree and temple cleansing were "the next day" after the entry (Mark 11:12). The withered fig tree was seen "in the morning" the day after the cleansing (Mark 11:20). Jesus taught "daily" in the temple (Luke 19:47). The tomb was found empty on the first day of the week (all four Gospels).

What We Have Inferred

The crucifixion was on Wednesday, based on the three-days-and-three-nights requirement combined with the two-Sabbath spice sequence. This is a necessary inference — no other day satisfies all of the textual constraints simultaneously.

The entry into Jerusalem was on Nisan 10 (Saturday), based on counting backward through Mark's "next day" sequence from the Wednesday crucifixion and counting backward from John's "six days before the Passover" using inclusive reckoning. Both paths converge on the same day independently.

The correspondence between Nisan 10 and the selection of the Passover lamb (Exodus 12:3) is a typological inference. The text does not say "Jesus entered Jerusalem on the day the Passover lamb was selected." We observe the alignment and note it. The timeline stands on the Gospel time markers regardless of whether the reader accepts the typological connection.

What the Text Does Not Say

The text never says "Friday." It says "the day of preparation" before a Sabbath that John specifically identifies as "a high day."

The text never says "Palm Sunday." It does not identify the day of the week for the entry into Jerusalem. That designation comes from church tradition.

The text never says "Easter." It says "the first day of the week."

The text never describes the moment of resurrection. It tells us the tomb was found empty early on the first day of the week. When precisely He rose is not stated.

These distinctions matter. The text is inspired. Tradition is not. Where the two conflict, the text has the authority.

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The tradition is old. But the text is older.

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No commentaries, no scholars, no denominational positions were consulted in the preparation of this study.

The text was the only source.